

about the state of the economy, the market, and the nation and tried to inject some fun into my musings. After all, the gain or loss for any quarter can be stated quickly, and any commentary after that is superfluous. As for market forecasts, they soon go stale. I decided I wouldn't be one of those fund runners who scribbles a page of bland economics followed by "Happy New Year, I'm sorry I lost all your money." If most mutual fund communications are both boring and wrong, well then, I figured, I'd rather be lively and wrong.

So I kept my stock market comment to bikini format. I wanted to cover the essential parts of the subject with a minimum of material. I then moved on to other matters of interest at the time, because there is little that happens in the world that isn't reflected, to some degree, in what prices investors will pay for stocks. And when it's appropriate—and sometimes when it's inappropriate—I prefer the lighter touch.

I decided also early on that I would file away any good quotes I came across in my reading and share them with my investor family at appropriate moments. Often, though, I find I have quotes echoing in my head whose authors I have forgotten. So I follow this rule: if you can't remember who said it, and it's about money, attribute it to John Maynard Keynes, and if it's not, credit Mark Twain.

Deciding to write lively letters turned out to be smart business strategy, though that wasn't my conscious motive at the time. By taking a different tack from my peers and treating the investment business with something less than reverential sobriety, I attracted attention to my scarcely known fund. I then and there concluded that, in this world, if you're too serious, nobody pays any attention to you. However profound and uplifting the essays of Ralph Waldo Emerson, it's perceptive, funny Mark Twain whom people read after high school.

This offbeat approach indeed succeeded in bringing the fund recognition. Newspaper and magazine reporters, weary of summa-